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Why LGBTQIA+ make sense in
fantasy.

Essay



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Acknowledgment

I am a straight, white male. I do not seek to speak on behalf of the LGBTQIA+ community simple discuss my perspective on this topic.

For the sake of convenience when writing I shall be using the term Queer to refer to all members of the LGBTQIA+ community.

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Why LGBTQIA+ make sense in fantasy.

Hello dear reader. Today I wish to discuss why the inclusion of queer people makes sense in fantasy. The reason why I am writing this essay is due to numerous factors, but primarily the strange notion I have seen online that queer characters existing in fantasy makes no sense.

I find this notion perplexing, as I see no reason why they don't make sense. What is inherently "wrong" with the inclusion of queer characters? Well, there are three main arguments presented for this, which I shall dismantle in this essay.

Let us begin.

Historical Accuracy

Our first argument used to discount queer characters is historical accuracy. This is in relation to historical fiction (a fictional story set in a real historical place and period). I know what you think I'm going to say: you can accept magic but not a queer person, what is wrong with you? While that is a valid counter, I shall present a more concrete argument.

Online there seems to be an incorrect notion that queer people have only started to exist in recent years. As I said, this is incorrect. Queer people have been around for as long as humanity has; the difference is that they were not seen as socially acceptable until recently (in the majority of cultures, at least). As a result of this social stigma, many queer people hid their identity, forcing themselves to conform to societal expectations.

For a recent example which I can point to in order to demonstrate this, I'd like to bring up Elton John, famous musical artist. He was married to a woman for four years before he publicly came out as gay.

Further, an author can actually utilise queer characters to tackle that stigma, using it to form the emotional core of their story: society seeking to suppress people. You don't need to be a queer person to understand that kind of pressure, because (I believe) every person has faced the crushing weight of societal expectations at some point, that pressure to conform.

It's Just Forced Diversity / Pandering

The second argument is that queer characters are "forced" and "pandering." "Critics" often claim that the inclusion of queer characters isn't organic to the story, but is instead a modern political statement or a marketing tactic added to tick a box. I believe people who say this are simply unhappy that others are happy.

An example that comes to my mind is people who argue against Harley Quinn being bisexual, primarily whenever she is dating Poison Ivy. I have heard people online decry this as forced, unnecessary and even incorrect. Focusing on that final

point, the people who believe it is incorrect often say that Harley was designed to be the Joker's girl and therefore should only date Joker. My question to them is: have you seen what Joker does to Harley? Like, seriously, he is not only verbally abusive to her but is often physically and emotionally abusive as well.

Further, Harley has evolved as a character since her introduction in *Batman: The Animated Series*. Additionally, in *Batman: The Animated Series* she is already hinted to have a more intimate relationship with Ivy than some believe. It seems as if these online commentators wish for these characters to never evolve, never grow as people, which is the opposite of what characters are supposed to do. Characters need to grow, else they are not characters but rather a sack of flesh.

In my opinion, very few instances of a queer character being included are simply pandering and box-ticking. Often it is simply because a creator wishes to include them. This strange opinion, that it is simply because queer characters are marketable, ignores a simple truth: queer people exist, thus creators often include queer characters to make their world feel as rich, varied and authentic as the real one.

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It Breaks the Lore / Internal Consistency

Our third point that is presented has to do with when queer characters simply exist. The argument some online have against this is that if a world is based on medieval or historical tropes, that world should have strictly traditional social norms, and the acceptance of queer people breaks the established rules of that

world.

My response to that is: it's fantasy. I know that sounds obvious, but some people simply seem incapable of understanding this. In a fantasy world, there will be alternative cultural norms. In a world where magic exists or gods walk the planes of the world, societal views on gender, love and family would naturally evolve differently. A culture might venerate shape shifters; there could be genderless deities. While I disagree that the Bible denounces queer people, I must mention that it has been used against them. But in a fantasy world, Christianity isn't generally the primary religion. The gods of that world might not be against queer people. Thus, the social taboo of being queer may not exist.

Additionally, I find it hilarious when people say it contradicts the lore, because, as is obvious to anyone who thinks for a second before speaking, the author is the one who makes the lore. Therefore, if an author decides that the culture of their world is accepting of queer people, who are you to go against that? You are a nobody in terms of control over their creative work. That isn't inconsistent with the world; that is the internal consistency of that world. We should not limit creatives from being creative by subjecting their stories to the arbitrary rules of the real world.

At the end of the day, fantasy has never been about copying real-world history, it has always been about imagining what could be. Queer people are not a modern invention, diversity is not a gimmick, and an author's world need only align with the rules the author put in place for it, not the narrow expectations of internet commentators. If a setting can accommodate ancient dragons, a dark sorcerer and divine pantheons, it can

certainly accommodate queer people simply existing, loving and adventuring.

